



Additional Guidelines - Startup Experience at 42 Paris

Summary:

This document complements the official Startup Experience guidelines provided in the general documentation. It outlines certain steps and requirements specific to the 42 Paris campus. Please read it carefully before applying.

Version 1

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Chapter I

Chapter I - Specific Rules at 42 Paris Campus

Your pitch deck should include:

- All required elements listed in the official Startup Experience documentation (see section III.1 - How to apply?)
- A 6-month roadmap outlining key milestones.
- A one-page long-term vision to show where you want to take the project beyond the initial 6 months
- A brief team presentation

I.1 Eligibility Requirements

This second professional experience takes place during the latter half of your curriculum and must meet the following requirements:

- **Duration:** The Startup Experience project must last at least 6 months on a full-time basis.

Think of this as your launchpad, as the goal is not to complete a pedagogical project, but to build something real and lasting.

Ideally, your startup keeps growing beyond the 6 months... and so do you, maybe even as an alumni !

- **Timing:** Ideally, this period should coincide with the time when "Piscines" are organized at your campus to free up space for incoming pisciners.

- **Purpose:** The Startup Experience is designed for students who want to launch a startup idea.

According to a widely accepted definition in the tech ecosystem:

"A startup is a temporary organization designed to search for a repeatable and scalable business model." **Steve Blank, The Startup Owner's Manual**

If you are creating a company that provides tech services that are not built to scale or iterate (like freelance web or app development, building websites or apps for clients, offering custom development services), your project will not fall under the startup category.

- **Founders:** to be eligible, you must also be part of the founding team of the startup. Freelancers, interns, or temporary contributors to a startup project are not eligible for the Startup Experience.
 - You can apply as a solo founder, as long as your project fits the startup definition above.
 - Groups are also welcome to apply - please refer to section I.3 to see how to proceed in that case.

I.2 How to apply

Before registering your Startup Experience project on the intranet, you must first submit your application to the 42 Paris staff.

This step is mandatory.

The first step is to send your pitch deck to relations-entreprises@42paris.fr. If your application is approved, you will then upload that same deck on the intranet in place of a traditional job contract or internship agreement.

- on with each person's role.
- A summary of your next steps.

There is no template.

Feel free to design the pitch in your own format, as long as the content is clear, structured, and easy to understand.

Once your pitch deck is received, the staff will get in touch with you to schedule a 1-hour meeting to review your application and next steps.

I.3 How to apply if the same project is led by several 42 students

If the project is led by several 42 students who would like to be evaluated for this Startup Experience:

- Please make sure to mention it when submitting your application.
- Everyone will be evaluated together with the same final evaluation.
- All members must be equally involved.

I.4 How the application will be evaluated

During the meeting, the team will ask you a few questions to determine if you are eligible for the Startup Experience. They will look at several key criteria, such as:

- Your availability to work full-time on the project for at least six months
- A clear and realistic project with strong development potential
- Completion of the Common Core
- Not being currently involved in another professional experience project at 42
- Having validated no more than two professional experience projects at 42
- Playing a meaningful role in the startup (holding shares is a strong indicator)
- The existence of a legal structure (recommended, but not mandatory at this stage) — *auto-entrepreneur* status is generally not suitable
- Valid and active social security coverage
- A clear explanation of your project's current status, especially if it already exists or has pivoted

The staff will validate your project based on your full-time commitment, project viability, and compliance with the startup criteria, then invite you to register on the intranet.

If the project is not validated you will need to refine your project before reapplying.

I.5 Starting the Startup Experience

1.5.1 On the intranet

First, you will have to subscribe to the project and then go to the companies section on the intra and click on “Create a new contract”.

When doing so, your campus will have to indicate you:

- To choose 42cursus Startup Experience as companies administration if you want to validate your professional experience with your startup.
- How to fill the form "The Company" / “Contract for Startup Experience”:
 - **User:** Enter your personal information.
 - **Company:** Write the name of your company and an address (either the registered address, Station F's address if you're incubated there, or your personal address if needed).
 - **Boss:** You can put your own information.
 - **Supervisor:** Indicate the name of your mentor or supervisor (see 1.5.3).
 - **Contract:**
 - Write a short paragraph about your startup main purpose, for example:
Revolutionary mobile App for disabled citizens in wheelchairs.
 - **Start date**
 - **35 hours per week** - Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday
 - **€0 per month**

Then, you will need to upload the document you previously sent to the *Corporate Relations* team with all the information about your startup.

1.5.2 Documentation

As your deck is only meant to convince your interlocutors on a first meeting, you need to make available more complete documentation on your startup project.

General information:

- Name, logo and email of the startup.
- Description of the startup.
- What is your startup going to make?
- Why did you pick this idea to work on?

About your development plan:

Detailed description of your product from a technical point of view. What do you aim to build: a mobile app, a web, a program, an API, a DB or something else?

Can you target to have a proof of concept in some weeks? And, what is the timeline for bringing the final product to market?

What stack are you going to implement for the different parts your product may have?

About your business model:

Detailed description of your product from a customer point of view. What are you going to offer/which problem does your service solve?

Are products or services in development or existing (and on the market)?

Who are you customers? How are you planning on contacting them?

Have you already raised funds? How are you planning on doing so?

We recommend you to write a short document with all this information, since you will have to submit later on in the process if you are selected. After providing this information you may be asked to have a short interview with your campus staff. If the project is solid enough and you are committed to work full-time on it for the next few months they will indicate to you how to subscribe to it. Otherwise, you may be asked to reevaluate your idea or to do a short trial period and come back to them later.

1.5.3 Supervisor / tutor

Who your tutor will be:

Your tutor is the person responsible for conducting your mid-term and final evaluations.

Rather than supervising your daily work like a traditional internship supervisor, they should act more like a mentor.

Their role involves supporting you as you explore and test your startup idea so it is important that they are familiar with your project and can follow its progress throughout the Startup Experience.

Who Can Be a Tutor?

Your tutor should be someone who has relevant experience in entrepreneurship or your specific field. This might include:

- Entrepreneurs or former entrepreneurs
- Professionals with deep expertise in your domain, such as VCs or Product Managers
- Members of the 42 community or external experts

If you are part of an incubator, the person overseeing your progress there could also serve as your tutor.

Similarly, if you are working with a mentor or expert who is actively involved, they might take on this role.

The choice of tutor should be discussed with the staff. If you don't have someone specific in mind, the staff can help connect you with a suitable individual.

What Is Expected from the Tutor?

Your tutor should:

- Participate in the monthly check-ins during the Startup Experience.
- Provide valuable insights and help you reflect on your strategy and execution throughout the Startup Experience.

They will receive a short guide outlining these expectations to clarify their role.

Chapter II - During the Startup Experience

II.1 - Specific notes for 42 Paris regarding follow-up

This startup allows you to realize your capacities in a real environment and to develop not only your entrepreneurial mindset but also your ability to self-manage and stay consistent over time.

To support your progress, the following follow-up conditions apply:

- You will be supervised by both a tutor and a member of the 42 Paris staff.
- A monthly check-in with both will help ensure you are on the right track.
- Weekly Accountability meetings:

In addition, you are expected to organize a weekly accountability meeting with one or two other students doing the Startup Experience.

This peer learning format is a key part of the experience. Each week, you should update a shared document (such as a Notion page) where you and your peers log:

- what you worked on
- what you plan to do next
- any blockers or key insights.

A short written summary of your weekly meeting must be sent to relations-entreprises@42paris.fr

II.2 - What to Prepare for Monthly Check-ins

Each monthly meeting is a chance to step back, reflect, and move forward with clarity. These meetings can include general updates but also follow a specific monthly theme to help you make progress on key startup milestones.

1 - Recommended General Structure

Here are some helpful guidelines to structure your monthly updates:

- **Key updates since the last meeting:**
 - What has been done or launched?
 - What has changed (in your product, team, positioning, etc.)?
 - Any strategic shifts?
- **Data & traction:**
 - User signups, client feedback, pre-orders, usage metrics.
 - Retention, conversion rates, or any other relevant KPIs.
- **Challenges or blockers:**
 - What's not working?
 - What are you unsure about?
 - Where do you need support?
- **Goals for the coming month:**
 - Priorities and experiments planned.
 - Hypothesis to test.
 - Key actions you want to focus on.
- **Ask or request:**
 - Any specific question?
 - Feedback needed ?
 - A contact or intro that could help?

2 - Recommended Monthly Themes

Each month, we will also focus on a dedicated theme:

- **Month 1: Business Model Canvas & Problem/Solution Fit**
Objective: Clearly define the problem to solve, the value proposition, and the initial project assumptions.
Examples of expected deliverables: A Business Model Canvas or Lean Canvas.
- **Month 2: Landing Page & First Field Feedback**
Objective: Build an online presence and test initial market interest.
Examples of expected deliverables: A Landing Page presenting the offer with a clear CTA (sign-up, waitlist, pre-orders) and/or proof of actual interest (number of waitlist sign-ups, number of feedback submissions, etc.).
- **Month 3: MVP Demo & First User Tests**
Objective: Validate market interest by testing the idea with real users.
Examples of expected deliverables: A functional MVP or prototype to test value with early users, a first round of field testing, a summary of key insights.
- **Month 4: Product Iteration & Growth Strategy**
Objective: Show how the solution evolved based on user feedback and outline the growth strategy.
Examples of expected deliverables: A list of improvements made, a product roadmap for the next few months, a review of your initial acquisition strategy.
- **Month 5: Finance & Scalability**
Objective: Demonstrate that your project is built on a viable and scalable business model, with a first structured approach to short- and medium-term financial planning.
Examples of expected deliverables: A financial forecast (revenue, costs, needs, profitability...) you can use <https://www.fisy.fr/> to help build it, a draft monetization or scaling strategy
- **Month 6: Pitch & What's Next**
Objective: Pitch the project and prepare for the next steps (incubation, pivot, fundraising, solo continuation, etc.).
Examples of expected deliverables: A full pitch deck, a 15-minute pitch in front of mentors, staff, and peers, a post-program action plan.

These themes are here to guide you. The midterm and final evaluations will be based on your deliverables, but you are free to present anything relevant to your startup. The goal is to help you progress and make better decisions.

II.3 - Specific Notes for 42 Paris Regarding Evaluation

The Startup Experience is part of your academic curriculum and includes a final evaluation based on two main components:

1 - Tutor Evaluation

Your assigned tutor will complete a mid-term evaluation and a final evaluation.

These evaluations will assess your overall progress, project execution, and the evolution of your startup over the 6-month period.

2 - Pitch Presentation & Peer Evaluation

At the end of your 6-months-pedagogical period of time, you will present your startup during a dedicated pitch session, either on-site or online, in front of a jury.

Format: 15-minute pitch + optional Q&A.

Jury composition: The jury will include a mix of your tutor, members of the 42 staff, other tutors from the Startup Experience project, and/or 42 students (especially those from the Startup Club or with startup experience).

Even if some jury members are students and not expert evaluators, they will all use a structured evaluation grid to ensure a fair, consistent, and meaningful assessment. The goal of this evaluation is to measure the technical success of your startup but also to reflect the work accomplished, the clarity of your presentation, and the progress made during your Startup Experience.

Final scoring will be calculated based on the average of all jury scores, and bonus points may apply (up to a total score of 125/100).

Chapter III - Commitment Rules

To ensure that the Startup Experience project remains a meaningful and productive experience, the following rules apply:

- The project may be discontinued if no significant progress is observed, based on pre-established and written criteria (to be detailed in the participation charter).
- If the project is cut, the student may not re-enroll immediately in the same project or topic.
- A student can only reapply to the Startup Experience on the same project after a minimum period of 3 months and only if they can demonstrate clear execution capabilities.

The final decision regarding re-enrollment remains with the 42 staff team.

These rules are designed to encourage accountability, foster focus, and ensure fair access to the Startup Experience project.

Chapter IV - The Corporate Relations Team

The Corporate Relations team is your main point of contact throughout the Startup Experience.

They will follow your project alongside your tutor to ensure smooth coordination and regular check-ins during the project.

If you have any questions or face any issues, reach out to them.

Chapter V - The 42 Startup Club and the 42 Incubator based at Station F

The Corporate Relations team also runs the 42 Startup Club and the 42 Incubator based at Station F.

If you are not yet a member, we strongly encourage you to sign up here : <https://s.42paris.fr/42-startup-club>

It will give you access to monthly events held at 42 and Station F and is open to all students and alumni who are building a startup or simply curious about entrepreneurship.

Participating in the Startup Experience does not automatically grant access to the incubator, but you will be able to apply to join it later on if your project evolves and fits the selection criteria.

Feel free to ask the team if you have any questions about the Incubator application process: incubateur@42.fr